Designing a Menstrual Hygiene Management Campaign in Rohingya Camp

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Problem Statement

In the Rohingya refugee camps, women face significant barriers to managing menstrual hygiene effectively, primarily due to a lack of clean water, poor sanitation facilities, and restrictive cultural and religious norms that curtail women's rights. Studies indicate that reproductive tract infections are about 70% more prevalent among women with inadequate menstrual hygiene [1]. To substantially reduce disease spread in these camps, it is crucial to improve Menstrual Hygiene educational programs for women, enhance menstruation-related facilities, and boost awareness among men about supporting women's health needs.

Stakeholder Analysis

Figure 1 below illustrates the relationship between the different stakeholders in the Rohingya camp and their level of interest and power.

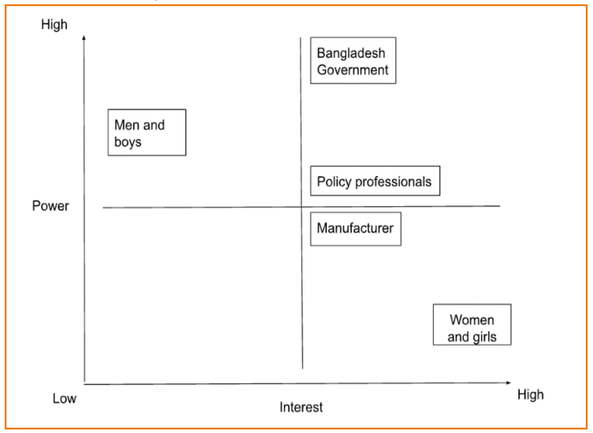


Figure 1 Stakeholders vs Power & Interest in Rohingya Camp

Design Objectives & Criteria

Table 1 Objectives and criteria of the design Solution

Objective	Criteria
Spread awareness on menstrual hygiene	• Increase premenstrual knowledge of girls aged 8-14 to 70% [2], [3]
Improve access to menstrual products	• Supply the 50% of women who use cloths with menstrual products.
Enhance sanitation infrastructure	• Develop efficient menstrual hygiene management MHM system to treat up to 90% of menstrual waste [4].

Design Solution

1. Develop Educational Programs for Menstrual hygiene

- Develop a comprehensive and culturally sensitive learning materials focusing on menstrual hygiene management, menstrual health and disease prevention in native language.
- Organize workshops for women and girls led by trained committee from the same community and background to foster trust.
- Establish a peer-to-peer education program where trained women educate others, helping to spread knowledge and overcome cultural barriers.

2. Improve water supply and sanitation infrastructure

- Increase access to clean water by constructing additional boreholes and water purification systems within the camps.
- Rebuild the sanitation facilities and improve the menstrual waste disposal systems by adopting the design of sanitation facilities illustrated in **figure 2** below.

3. Enhance Supply of Menstrual Hygiene Products

- Partner up with big fashion companies in Bangladesh to design innovative recycled pads and other menstrual products which are cost-effective and environmentally friendly.
- Partner with international NGOs, local governments, and health organizations to secure funding and resources.
- Advocate for policies that support menstrual hygiene management as a basic health right in refugee camps.

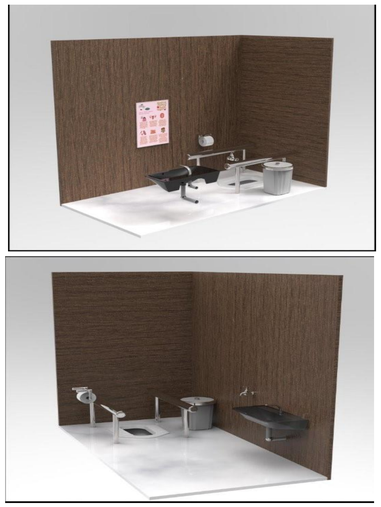


Figure 2 Female friendly sanitation facilities to be built in camps

Technical Summary

The primary goal of this initiative is to enhance menstrual hygiene management within Rohingya refugee camps to reduce the incidence of reproductive tract infections among women, thereby improving overall community health and promoting gender equity. This comprehensive project focuses on substantial improvements across infrastructure, education, and community engagement, specifically addressing the needs for better water and sanitation facilities, educational outreach, and supportive community practices in menstrual health management.

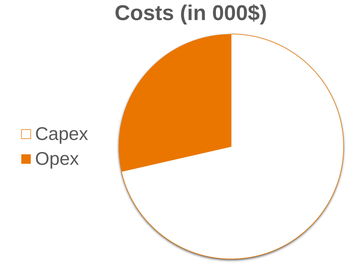
The comprehensive solution for improving menstrual hygiene management in Rohingya refugee camps integrates several crucial components: infrastructural upgrades, educational initiatives, and community engagement. Enhanced sanitation facilities, constructed with durable, weather-resistant materials, feature lockable doors for security and privacy, ergonomic interiors for comfort, and corrosion-resistant piping with dedicated water sources for optimal hygiene. Each unit includes a closed sanitary waste bin to ensure hygienic disposal of menstrual products, mitigating health risks and odors. To educate and empower the community, educational posters in Burmese and Rohingya are displayed within these facilities, and regular workshops are conducted by culturally aligned health educators. Additionally, community engagement efforts focus on involving men and community leaders through educational sessions to foster support for menstrual hygiene, aiming to reduce stigma and promote gender-sensitive practices. This integrated approach not only addresses immediate health needs but also works towards long-term behavioral changes and community acceptance, crucial for sustaining health improvements and enhancing gender equity within the camps.

Risks & Constrains

- **Harassment and Violence:** Women and girls seeking to participate in educational programs on menstrual hygiene may face harassment or violence, which could lead to social ostracism. This risk underscores the need for secure, private spaces within the sanitation facilities and the inclusion of community awareness programs that specifically target men and boys.
- **Cultural and Religious Resistance**: Deep-rooted cultural and religious beliefs may present substantial resistance to the changes proposed in menstrual hygiene practices.
- **Resource and Infrastructure Limitations**: The availability of education materials and the construction of adequate sanitation facilities are constrained by resource limitations.

Economic Analysis

Strategically, the project should focus on securing multi-year funding commitments from international donors, NGOs, and government bodies to ensure continuity and effectiveness of the programs.



Additionally, rigorous monitoring and evaluation are essential to measure effectiveness, adapt strategies, and demonstrate the economic and social value to stakeholders to continue garnering support

Implementation timeline

Planning and Partnership	Education & Infrastructure	Implement and distribute	Assess and scaling
- Negotiate partnerships.	- Start construction.	- Distribute free menstrual supplies.	- Evaluate the effectiveness of the design solution.
- Design educational materials	- Launch educational programs		- Scale up to other camps.

Contribution to SDG

The initiative to improve menstrual hygiene management in Rohingya refugee camps directly supports Sustainable Development Goals by enhancing women's health and education. By providing secure sanitation facilities and clean water, it reduces health risks associated with poor menstrual hygiene and promotes gender equality. This approach not only addresses immediate health needs but also fosters a supportive environment for women, aligning with global goals for health, education, and gender equality in vulnerable communities.

[1] Chaudhuri, S., Paul, K. and Maiti, A. (2020). Menstrual hygiene practices among women aged 15-49 years attending a medical college hospital in Kolkata: A cross-sectional study. Journal of Family Medicine and Primary Care, 9(9), p.4699. doi: https://doi.org/10.4103/jfmpc.jfmpc_718_20., [2] "Freedom," www.aci-bd.com. https://www.aci-bd.com/freedom.html., [3] The World Bank, "Menstrual Hygiene Management Enables Women and Girls to Reach Their Full Potential," World Bank, May 25, 2018. https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/feature/2018/05/25/menstrual-hygiene-management ., [4] SEO, "Menstrual Hygiene Management - Waste Disposal Techniques," Citron Hygiene, Aug. 31, 2023. https://www.citronhygiene.com/resources/menstrual-waste-disposal-techniques-hygiene-management/#Understanding_Menstrual_Waste (accessed May 30, 2024) .